

PLSC 476: Empirical Legal Studies

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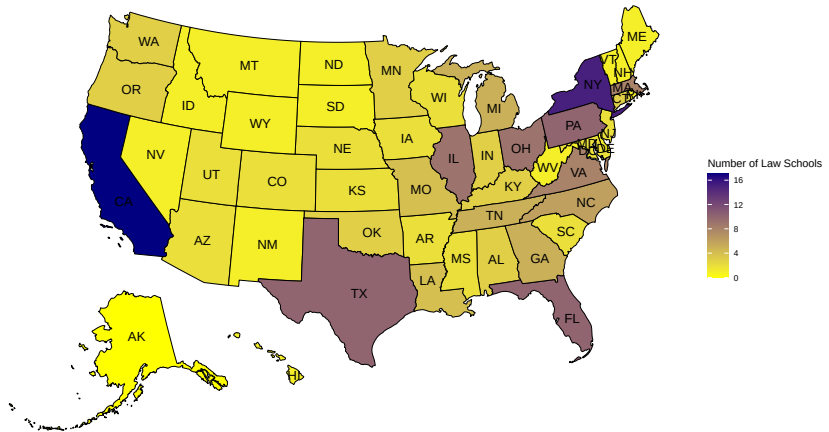
November 6, 2025

Legal Education and Bar Passage

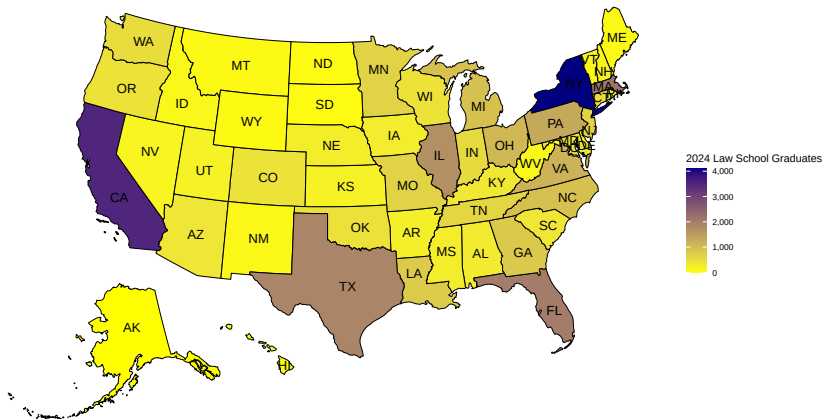
- Bar passage is required to receive a license to practice law in the U.S.
- Each state (and D.C.) is responsible for creating, administering, and evaluating its own bar exam
- 36 states / jurisdictions have adopted the Uniform Bar Exam, administered by the National Conference of Bar Examiners
- Following graduation, J.D. holders typically take the bar exam in July; if they do not pass, there is typically a second examination in February
- In most states, potential attorneys can take the bar exam as many times as they wish

- <https://analytix.accesslex.org/download-dataset>
- Data on $N = 196$ ABA-accredited law schools in the U.S. (from 2024)
- Things we're going to focus on today:
 - Law school characteristics +
 - Class / student characteristics =
 - Bar passage results
- Contains many, many other variables:
 - Institutional resources (libraries, etc.)
 - Students: full-time vs. part-time status
 - Scholarships, grants, etc.
 - Employment status (in very great detail; part- vs. full-time, temporary vs. permanent, etc.)
 - Most common state of employment

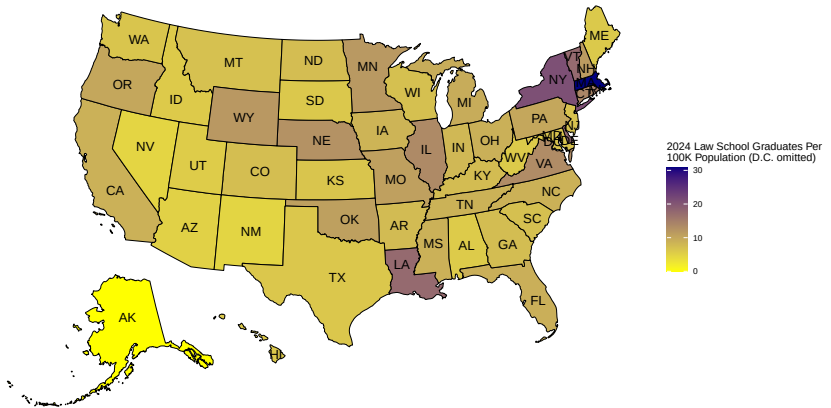
Law Schools Per State (2024)



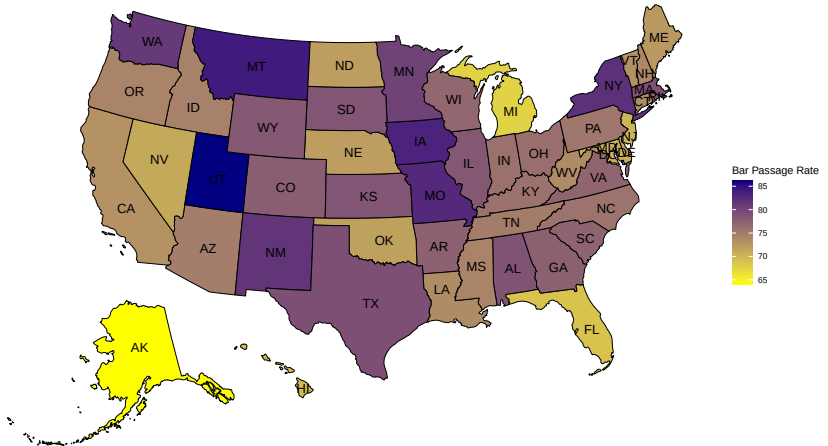
Law Graduates, by State (2024)



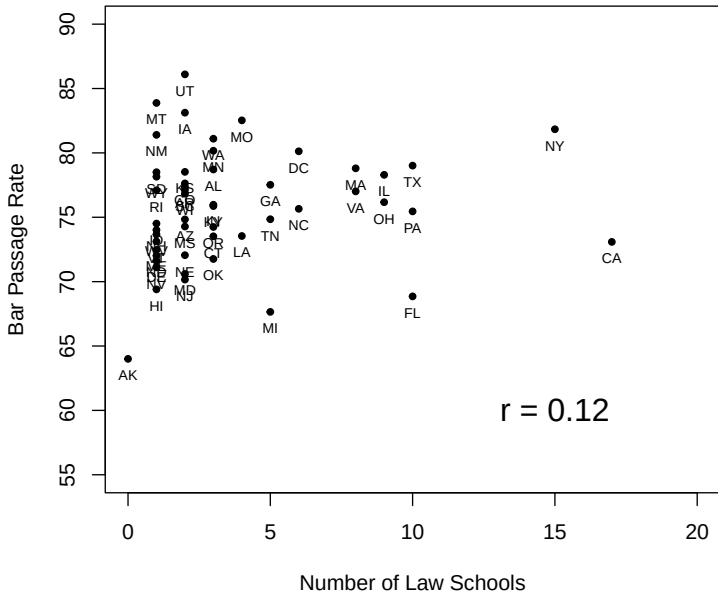
Law Graduates Per 100,000 Population (2024)



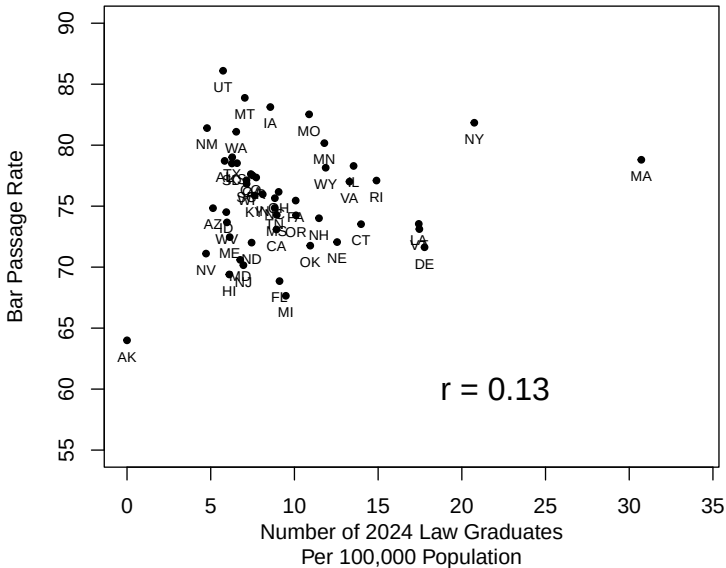
Bar Passage Rates, 2024



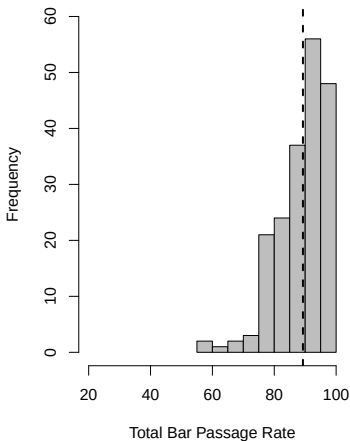
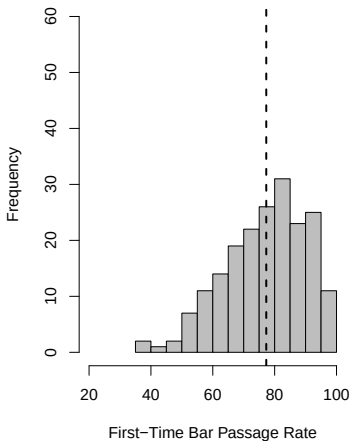
Bar Passage Rates and $N_{\text{Law Schools}}$ (2024)



Bar Passage Rates and N_{Law} Graduates (2024)



First-Time and Total Bar Passage Rates (2024)



Best and Worst: First-Time Bar Passage

Top 10:

School	Pass Rate
University of Wisconsin	100
Stanford University	97
Yale University	97
University of Chicago	97
University of Michigan	97
New York University	97
Vanderbilt University	97
University of Virginia	97
Boston College	96
Harvard University	96

Bottom 10:

School	Pass Rate
Widener Commonwealth	54
Barry University	53
Southern University	53
Ohio Northern University	51
University of Puerto Rico	51
California Western School of Law	48
District of Columbia	48
Inter American University of Puerto Rico	45
Florida A&M University	40
Thomas M. Cooley Law School	37

Best and Worst: Total Bar Passage

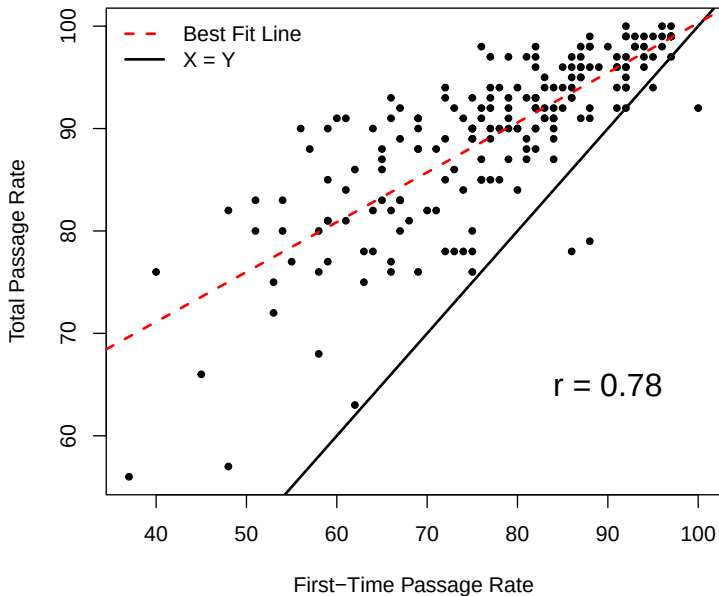
Top 10:

School	Pass Rate
University of Chicago	100
Harvard University	100
University of Kansas	100
Stanford University	99
Yale University	99
New York University	99
Vanderbilt University	99
University of Virginia	99
University of Pennsylvania	99
Brigham Young University	99

Bottom 10:

School	Pass Rate
St. Thomas University (Florida)	76
Florida A&M University	76
Vermont Law School	75
Barry University	75
Southern University	72
Western State College of Law	68
Inter American University of Puerto Rico	66
Pontifical Catholic University of P.R.	63
District of Columbia	57
Thomas M. Cooley Law School	56

First-Time and Total Bar Passage Rates (2024)

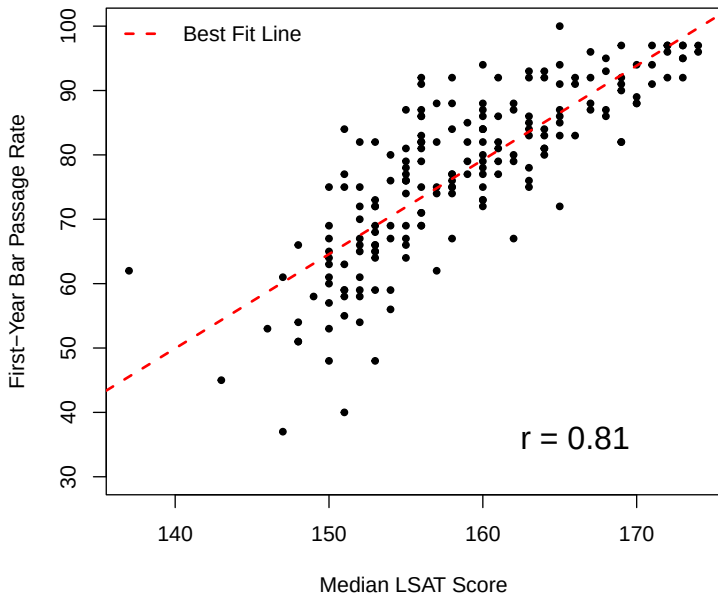


Bar Passage Determinants

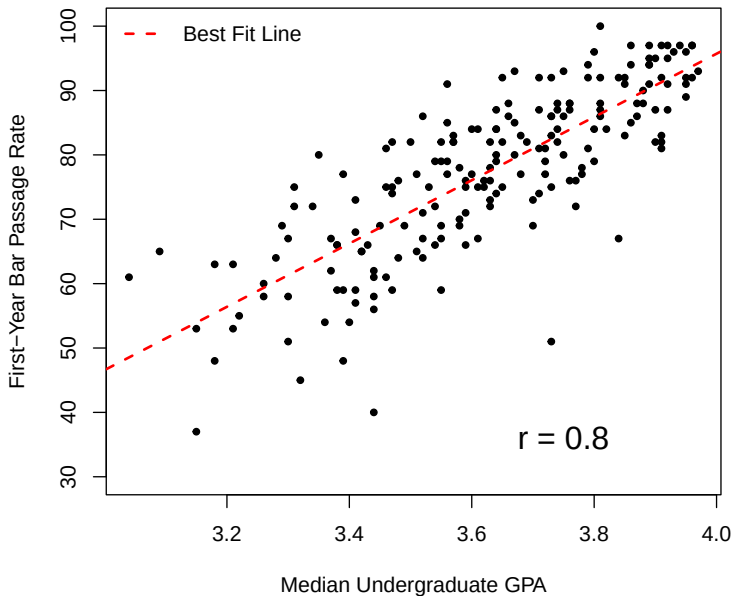
- “Inputs”: Student quality
 - LSAT
 - Undergraduate GPA
 - Selectivity
- School characteristics¹
 - Public vs. Private
 - Size
 - Cost
- Context / location

¹We're not going to consider rankings, because they are a [mess](#).

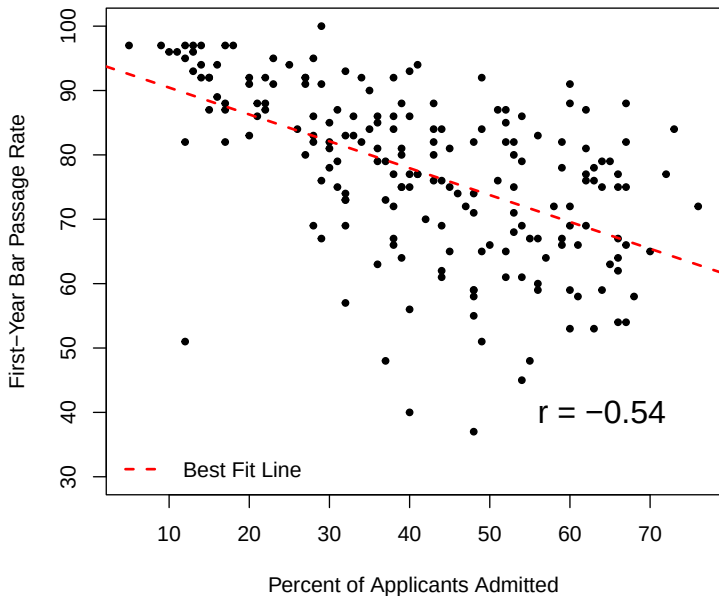
First-Time Bar Passage by Median LSAT (2024)



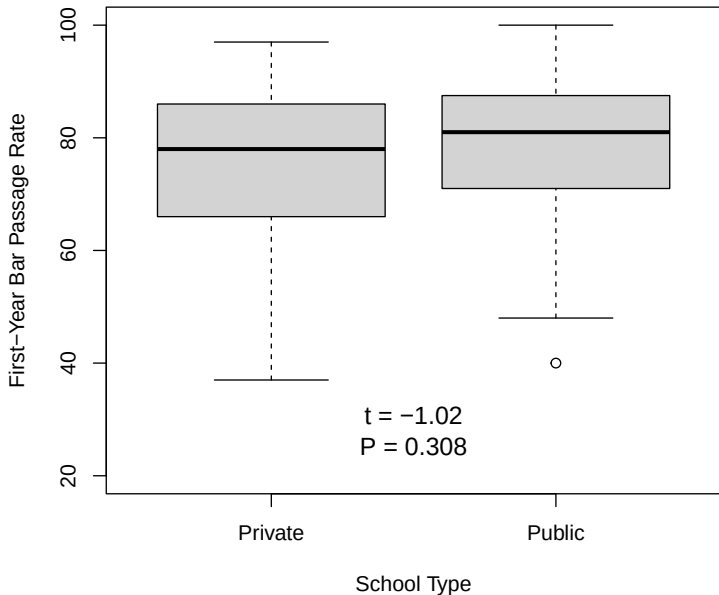
First-Time Bar Passage by Median UGPA (2024)



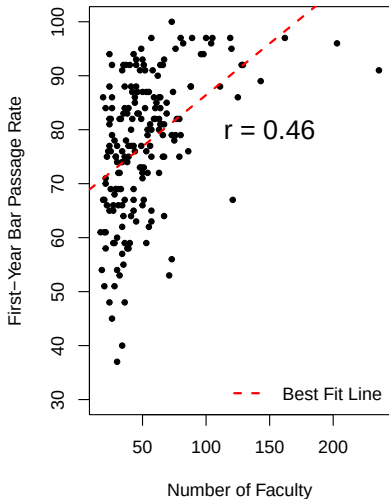
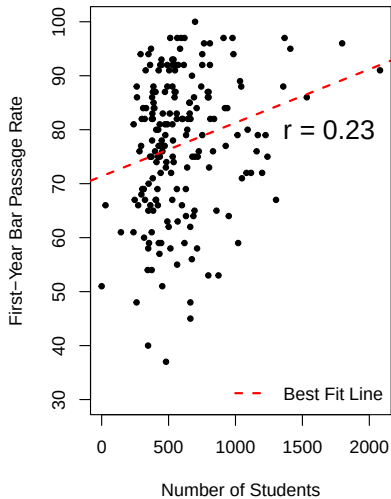
First-Time Bar Passage by Admission Rates (2024)



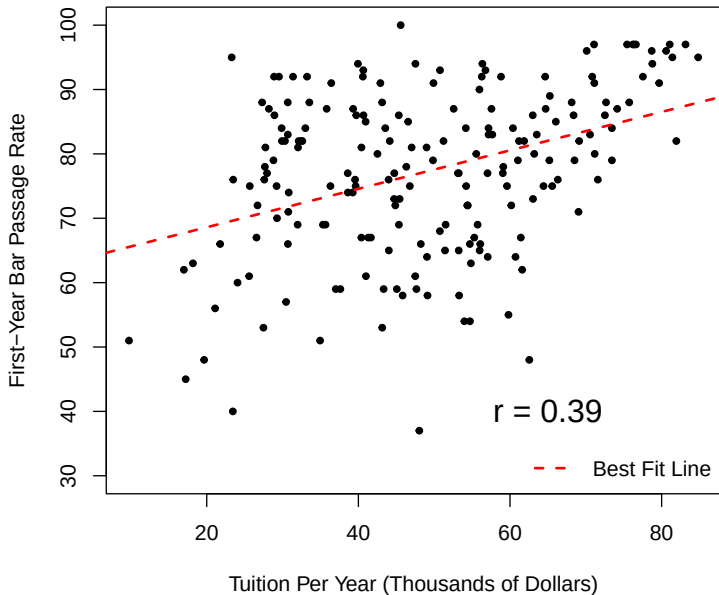
First-Time Bar Passage by School Type (2024)



First-Time Bar Passage and School Size (2024)



First-Time Bar Passage and School Cost (2024)



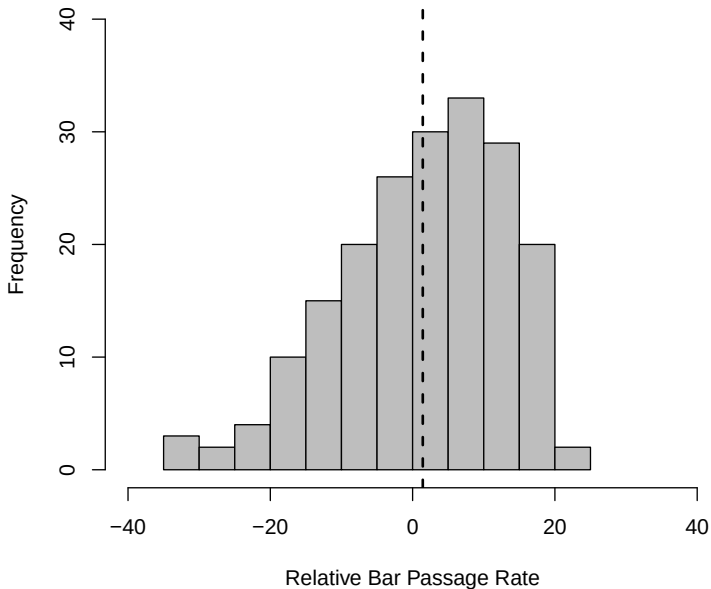
First-Time Bar Passage: Multivariate Analysis

	First-Time Bar Passage Rate
Median LSAT	1.302*** (0.241)
Median UGPA	22.460*** (5.825)
Admitted Percentage	0.125** (0.050)
Public School	-0.856 (1.568)
Number of Students	0.001 (0.003)
Number of Faculty	-0.056 (0.038)
Annual Cost (\$1000s)	-0.041 (0.063)
Constant	-211.100*** (25.100)
Observations	194
R ²	0.705
Adjusted R ²	0.694

Note:

* p<0.1; ** p<0.05; *** p<0.01

“Relative” Bar Passage Rates (2024)



First-Time and Relative Bar Passage

	First-Time Bar Passage Rate	Relative Bar Passage Rate
Median LSAT	1.302*** (0.241)	0.357 (0.230)
Median UGPA	22.460*** (5.825)	38.440*** (5.542)
Admitted Percentage	0.125** (0.050)	0.013 (0.047)
Public School	-0.856 (1.568)	-1.067 (1.492)
Number of Students	0.001 (0.003)	0.002 (0.003)
Number of Faculty	-0.056 (0.038)	-0.044 (0.036)
Annual Cost (\$1000s)	-0.041 (0.063)	-0.044 (0.059)
Constant	-211.100*** (25.100)	-191.200*** (23.890)
Observations	194	194
R ²	0.705	0.661
Adjusted R ²	0.694	0.648

Note:

* p<0.1; ** p<0.05; *** p<0.01

Predictions and Relative Performance

Our model *predicts*:

$$\hat{Y}_i = \hat{\beta}_0 + \hat{\beta}_1 X_{1i} + \hat{\beta}_2 X_{2i} + \dots + \hat{\beta}_k X_{ki}$$

The *residual* is:

$$\hat{u}_i = Y_i - \hat{Y}_i$$

Residuals indicate *relative performance*:

- $\hat{u}_i > 0 \leftrightarrow$ the school's bar passage rate is higher than the model predicts
- $\hat{u}_i < 0 \leftrightarrow$ the school's bar passage rate is lower than the model predicts

Overperformers and Underperformers

Top 10:

School	Relative Performance
Pontifical Catholic University of P.R.	15.72
Texas Tech University	15.26
Drake University	15.22
South Texas College of Law	14.85
Louisiana State University	14.14
University of Wisconsin	13.30
Pennsylvania State University-Penn State Law	12.05
Washburn University	11.71
University of Montana	11.56
Northern Kentucky University	11.42

Bottom 10:

School	Relative Performance
Florida A&M University	-24.33
California Western School of Law	-19.07
University of Puerto Rico	-18.04
Wayne State University	-17.61
University of Illinois	-17.21
Thomas M. Cooley Law School	-16.78
Willamette University	-13.92
University of Detroit Mercy	-12.67
Santa Clara University	-11.76
University of Florida	-10.71